

Moses Yang

Through the mud

I still remember
the time when I played
my perfect, golden, horn.
I could show my emotions,
and tell all my stories,
with a tube of metal
and a puff of wind.

Time for 2nd period;
it's band class.
Smells of metallic spit;
it's familiar.
We're playing some march;
it's staccato.

But as the melody starts,
I start to lose track, and
my upbeats are downbeats
downbeats are upbeats
my upbeats are—
Stop! Stop! You're Slow!
My band teacher shouts:
you play like you're dragging
a fridge through the mud!

And without a thought,
I start to imagine:
my feet stuck in slush,
slick yet strangled and
choked to submission
as I
Push! Push! Push into the ground!

But the fridge right behind me,
attached by a rope—He
tightens his grip, with
knuckles white, and a

cheesy grin, digging his
claws deep into my back.

It hurts like hell, but
if I don't run now, I know
I never will. So I
dig my digits deep
slowly move forward, but
at this pace, it won't be
enough.

I won't get to the end,
the white checkered flag,
where the chords will strike,
and the gong will hit. I'm
sinking and drowning
breathless
as the mud drinks my shoes.

But like a crescendo, I
start soft and slow.
If I crawl and I crawl,
and I crawl and I crawl,
at this rate, it will be

Enough!

My band teacher screams.
If you're just gonna sleep,
you might as well sleep.
But don't do it here,
not in my room,
where you slow down my rhythm:

Dragging
a fridge
through
the mud.